businesses and the self-employed, for example, had the effect of driving some into the black market, and leading others to simply close.

From *Perfeccionamiento* to Recentralization

From 2003 to the present recentralization has predominated. If many of the 1993–96 reforms went in the direction of market opening, the period after 2003 saw an attempt to restrict and turn back some of these reforms. Carmelo Mesa-Lago describes this period as one of "drastic recentralization measures in economic decision making and further reduction of the small private sector."[3] If the reforms slowed after 1996, they positively reversed in late 2005, in what Pérez-López termed "rectification redux."[4] "If defined as a time span of policy experimentation and reform," he writes, "the special period is over."[5]

The architects of the market opening were removed from the Cuban Cabinet. The Minister of Economics and Planning, the Minister of Finance and Prices, and the Minister of Basic Industry, all of whom were involved in the earlier reforms, were all replaced between 2003 and 2004.[6]

One example of recentralization was de-dollarization. In late 2003 the government introduced the "convertible peso." Cubans could still have dollars – but they couldn't spend them. First they would have to change them into convertible pesos, which would from then on be the only currency accepted at Cuba's hard-currency businesses. The dollar stores became "convertible peso stores." In May 2004, prices in the convertible peso stores were raised between 10 and 35 percent, while in June 2004 peso salaries were raised. All of these measures served as a kind of levy on dollar-holders, forcing them to subsidize the peso economy. They could be seen, alternately, as an unjustified punishment for the winners in the new economy, or as an attempt to restore a measure of equity.

"According to official sources," wrote economist Mario González Corzo with some skepticism, "de-dollarization represents an attempt to